

Zach Strickland, RHP, UCLA

2026 Stats: 2.82 ERA/0.861 WHIP/38.1 IP/52 K/6 BB/8.67 K:BB

6-2, 200

Metrics

FB: 93.5/19.5 IVB/8.1 HB/-4.46 VAA/5.9 relH/6 ext/32.5 AA/40.3% zone/62.1% usage/2340 rpm

CB: 75/-10.8 IVB/-16.6 HB/-10.2 VAA/37.9 AA/30% zone/3.3% usage/2640 rpm

SL: 83.9/8.3 IVB/-7.5 HB/-7.22 VAA/31.2 AA/39.4% zone/28.1% usage/2510 rpm

CH: 84.2/8.8 IVB/15.3 HB/-7.17 VAA/34.7 AA/28.2% zone/6.5% usage/1550 rpm

Write-up

Strickland emerged as one of the most dominant relief arms on the West Coast in 2026, pairing elite strike throwing with a fastball-slider combination that consistently overwhelmed hitters. The compact right-hander attacks with aggression, filling the zone while rarely issuing free passes, as evidenced by just six walks across 38.1 innings. His profile is built around carrying fastball traits and a hard slider that both play well against hitters from either side, while a sparsely used curveball and changeup provide occasional looks to keep hitters honest. The present command, coupled with two above-average pitches, gives Strickland one of the safer bullpen profiles in the class with the potential to move quickly through a professional system.

The FB is the driving force behind the arsenal. Averaging 93-94 mph with 19.5 inches of induced vertical break and a decently flat -4.46 VAA, the pitch explodes through the top of the strike zone with true riding life. Despite only average extension, the combination of elite carry and a average release height allows the ball to consistently miss barrels above the zone. When he got the pitch gloveside, he also got the FB to cut meaningfully, a shape that will only play up in the future. Strickland attacked with the heater over 60% of the time and still produced excellent swing-and-miss numbers while maintaining a strong zone rate. More importantly, hitters rarely forced him into disadvantage counts because he consistently landed the pitch early before expanding above the zone with two strikes. The

command separates the pitch from many similar movement profiles, allowing the fastball to play a full grade above its velocity. 60/60+ pitch

The CB is used sparingly but provides a distinctly different look than his primary breaker in the slider.

Thrown around 75 mph with elite depth and excellent spin, it creates significant velocity separation while dropping sharply beneath the zone. This was the pitch that awed scouts out of high school.

Because hitters primarily gear up for the fastball and slider combination, the curveball serves more as a surprise offering than a featured weapon. Landing it backdoor to lefties was its primary usage, being effective at stealing strikes. The shape flashes average to above-average, but the limited usage suggests it functions primarily as a show-me pitch rather than a consistent part of his attack plan. 45/50 pitch

The SL is an ideal complement to the fastball and projects as another above-average offering. Sitting around 84 mph with excellent depth and moderate sweep, the pitch tunnels well off the heater before diving beneath barrels late. The slider sweep plays up due to the pure carry slider shape he creates.

Strickland showed confidence throwing it for strikes early in counts while also burying it below the zone as his primary put-away pitch. The pitch consistently generated chase and empty swings against both right- and left-handed hitters, giving him a true finishing weapon. The overall shape, command, and sequencing make it a legitimate professional out pitch. 55/60 pitch

The CH rounds out the repertoire but remains the least-developed offering. The pitch features solid fading action with enough horizontal separation from the fastball to project as an occasional weapon against left-handed hitters. However, its limited usage indicates Strickland has little reason to move away from his primary fastball-slider pairing, particularly in shorter outings. If he eventually transitions into a starting role, continued development of the changeup would become more important. As a reliever, it is simply another look hitters must account for. 45/50 pitch